

What are the barriers that limit the utilization of central and state government schemes among rural women entrepreneurs in Telangana, and how do these barriers differ by education, caste, or income level?

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Abstract

In the 21st century, the vital role that women play across the world is extensively evident. They are in no sense inferior to men, and this reflects upon in every field and sector of work including entrepreneurship. However, is the idea of becoming an entrepreneur the same for every woman? This study will take this up in detail and will primarily discuss women entrepreneurs of Telangana with its context rooted in rural and underprivileged women, and it will pivot around government schemes and various types of barriers that disrupt the process of the beneficiaries utilizing the schemes. It will also talk deliberately on how these barriers affect different women and the possible solutions that may be incorporated. The paper will dive into government schemes, general safety and security of women in the country, and ultimately, the way forward.

Keywords: Entrepreneur, Woman, Telangana, Government, Scheme, Crime, Barriers, Education, Infrastructure, Digitalization

Introduction

In recent years, the significance that women entrepreneurs play in India's economic development is becoming increasingly clear. Specifically, women entrepreneurs in rural areas are being recognized as key drivers of economic growth by the government of India. Entrepreneurship gives rural women the opportunity to gain economic independence, the empowerment to make decisions and it allows for job creation at a local level. Despite an increase in participation of women in entrepreneurship, they still only make up a fraction of the entrepreneurs in India.

An entrepreneur is defined as a person who possesses an understanding of how a particular market operates, teams this knowledge up with innovation and “creates” a new business (Hayes, 2024). Often, an entrepreneur is confused with a “businessman”, and other than being more gender inclusive, the term entrepreneur also denotes more autonomy and authority: both in taking risks and yielding rewards. Gone are the days when only men could go out and be entrepreneurs while women were meant to sit with their talents and desires at home. This paper is centered around women entrepreneurship; their trajectories, achievements, changing socio-political environment and challenges they face.

In the case of India, many women have, since time immemorable, been co-partners with men in running businesses but their share was usually limited to sustenance. It can be said that from around the 18th to 19th century, the first independent women entrepreneurs began to rise. Their businesses were initially limited to small retail shops or mini handlooms. During the British rule, various initiatives were taken which relaxed the boundaries women worked in, and this led to many more women coming to the forefront with innovative ideas and courage. The state of events kept improving with the turn of the 20th century, but this change was occurring gradually. It was found in the 1981 census report that there were nearly 1.5 lakhs self-employed women in India which formed just over 5% of the total self-employed people in the country. It was almost a decade after this census that the economic reforms were introduced in 1991. The new economic policy adopted by India stressed on opening up of the economy; on Liberalization, Privatization and Globalization. Following the reforms, avenues for more opportunities opened and the country saw a new wave of entrepreneurship infused with the rise of urbanization, technological advancements and rapid infrastructural growth. This also reflected in the rise of women entrepreneurship as according to the official reports of the Indian government, there were nearly 3 lakh women entrepreneurs in the country during 1995-96 and

they now formed over 11% of the total self-employed population (Lubna, 2019). Since then, the situation has improved through socio-political changes and government intervention. It is, however, apparent that a lot still needs to be done in this sector. There is statistical data that supports this. Even as of 2024, there were just 14% of women entrepreneurs responsible for less than a fifth of the country's micro, small and medium enterprises. India also ranks 57th out of 65 countries in women's entrepreneurship globally, with only 2.16% women's involvement in early-stage entrepreneurial activities. Only 14% of tech unicorns (privately held tech start-ups valued at 1 billion USD or more) have at least one female founder. India has grown from having 3,000 start-ups in 2014 to now over around 11,000 in 2020. Yet, the number of start-ups with at least one female founder declined from 17% in 2018 to 12% in 2019 (Bazaz, 2024). The situation is grave and hence, requires more structured reforms.

The government's involvement in the push for rural women entrepreneurship is highlighted through state and central schemes which provide these entrepreneurs with necessities such as access to capital, skill development and training, market support and mentorship. Through the empowerment of rural women, schemes can contribute to inclusive economic growth and narrow gender-based disparities at a state and national level. The government aims to intervene in this way to help rural women develop the skills required to start, manage and successfully maintain an enterprise. Vocational training, workshops and financial literacy programs offered through such schemes all act as a means of bridging the gap between rural women and the opportunity to run successful ventures. Government schemes address the issues of lack of collateral by offering collateral free loans and a multitude of other benefits, this allows women to gain access to capital which they otherwise would not be able to. These schemes are designed with the aim of ameliorating gender-based disparities and fostering rural self-reliance. However, these schemes lack in certain areas such as the fact that many are insufficient in addressing the diverse needs of an entrepreneur.

History of Entrepreneurship Amongst the Women of Telangana

When it comes to elegant female leadership or women being in control of finances and culture, the history of Telangana is second to none. Whether it is women being in charge of education and *Stridhan* (personal wealth including land ownings and jewels) during Vedic and pre-colonial ages or ruling queens (Rawan239, 2019), courtesans (*Tawaifs*) such as the renowned Mah Laqa Bai earning their fortune through dance, poetry and other forms of art (Rekhta, 2025) and self-sustaining temple *Devdasis* who were also connoisseurs of culture and arts during 10th to 14th centuries (Thapar, 2002, p.391). Although the practice of *Devdasi* is primarily associated with the Hyosala kingdom of present-day Karnataka, it had also existed in many regions which form present-day Telangana (Harishankar and Priyamvada).

During the colonial period, although there were many significant women's reforms in women's education, notably through the elite and educated Muslim women of Hyderabad (Pande, 2012) and eminent female figures like Durru Shehvar Sultan, who was a Turkish princess married to the Nizam of Hyderabad in 1932 and who, even after the falling apart of her marriage, stayed in Hyderabad and championed for women's rights and founded and laid stones of some of the most important colleges and hospitals in the region (Heritage times, 2018), the majority of women suffered from economic seclusion, *Purdah* and compulsory domestic workload (Rawan239, 2019b).

Post-independence, the scenario began to change, and the state of Telangana saw the rise of eminent women who laid the foundation for a more inclusive gender equality and socio-political empowerment of women. Some of these women were Rani Kumudini Devi, who became the first female mayor of Hyderabad in 1962 and undertook many initiatives for social upliftment (The Hindu, 2020), Eshwari Bai, a member of the legislative assembly and funder of

the Republican Party of India who fought caste discrimination and women's education (Thatipalli, 2020) and Jayamma Bandari, a young orphan who rose from the hells of a brothel, found *Chaitanya Mahila Mandali* and rescued thousands of young girls from prostitution (Reflections Team, 2020). She was also awarded with the *Nari Shakti Puraskar (2017)* in 2018 (PIB, 2018). Although these women were not entrepreneurs themselves, they paved the path for exemplary entrepreneurs like Monika Misra who founded iKeva (Das, 2020), Vani Kola who founded Kalaari Capital (Bothra, 2023), Mythreyi Kondapi who founded Startoon Labs (Das, 2020) and thousands of similar women who dreamt of financial freedom.

After understanding the basics of female led entrepreneurship and their brief history in India and specifically Telangana, it becomes very important to also know the ground reality at present, part of which includes what is being done by those in power. The next chapter will deal with the government policies in India and Telangana related to women entrepreneurship and how they affect the market.

Government Schemes for Women Entrepreneurs

The concerning statistics like increasing crimes against women, low literacy among females and the persistent oppression of patriarchy^[1] are not unknown to the governments either and although there are many women still oppressed, unsafe and illiterate in the country, there are many public policies in action and attempting to improve the situation. Given below is a self-made table that talks about some of these policies that are implemented by the government to India to safeguard the rights of women are as follows:

Name of the Scheme	Year of Commencement	About it
Women Helpline Number 181	3 December 2018	24x7 emergency helpline for women in distress.
Beti Bachao Beti Padhao	22 January 2015	Campaign for improving child sex ratio and promoting girl child education.
Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY)	2010 (as Indira Gandhi MSY), renamed PMMVY in 2017	Cash incentive scheme for pregnant and lactating mothers.
One Stop Centre (OSC)	2015	Centers for integrated support to women affected by violence under Nirbhaya Fund.
State Resource Centre for Women	1972-73	Scheme providing safe and affordable accommodation for working women.
Kishori Shakti Yojana	31 August 2007	Scheme for adolescent girls'' empowerment

		through health, nutrition, and skills
Compensation Scheme for Women Victims of Sexual Assault (NALSA)	2018	Compensation to victims/survivors of sexual assault under NALSA guidelines.
Haryana Kanya Kosh (Part of <i>Aapki Beti</i> , <i>Humari Beti</i> scheme)	2015	Fund for welfare and empowerment of girl children born in Haryana, deposits Rs 21,000 into the account of the first girl child in SC/BPL families and the second child of families of any caste, with a maturity amount of Rs 1 lakh upon the girl's 18th birthday
Scheme for Relief and Rehabilitation of Women Acid Victims	2018 (applies to victims after 2 May 2011)	Financial aid and rehabilitation for women acid attack survivors.
Protection Against	2005 (enforced from 26	Legal framework for

Domestic Violence Act	Oct 2006)	protecting women against domestic violence.
State Level Women Awards	Around 2020	Awards to recognize women's achievements on state level

Central Government's Policies for Women Entrepreneurs

This sub chapter will discuss some schemes launched by the central government of India for upliftment of women entrepreneurs, especially those belonging to under-privileged categories.

An important scheme in this category is the *Mahila Udyam Nidhi* Scheme launched by the Small Industries Development Bank of India (SIDBI) which is implemented to offer financial assistance to help women establish their small scale ventures or expand their existing developments like small manufacturing or production units. Under this, a loan amount up to 10 lakh rupees can be availed which has to be repaid in up to 10 years (Piramal Finance, 2025).

Another significant scheme of almost similar nature is the *Mudra Yojana* for women. This has been implemented by MUDRA (Micro Units Development and Refinance Agency) launched in 2015 under Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana. It offers women loans in 3 categories; *Shishu* (startups), *Kishor* (Business growth) and *Tarun* (Business expansion) encompassing monetary brackets of up to rupees 50,000, 50,000 to 5 lakh and 5 lakhs to 10 lakhs respectively. The most beneficial part of this scheme is that it requires no collateral assurance and allows a flexible repayment tenure (Piramal Finance, 2025).

The next important scheme is the *Bhartiya Mahila* Bank Business loan scheme which was implemented by *Bhartiya Mahila* bank which later merged into the State Bank of India. This scheme promises bigger sums of money compared to the ones discussed above and is especially enjoyed by women in both urban and rural areas who need their industry, marketing and even retail businesses' expenses covered. It provides loans up to rupees 20 crores for manufacturing businesses on concessional interest rates and asks no collateral on loans up to 1 crore rupees (Piramal Finance, 2025).

"Stand-Up India" is yet another important initiative implemented by the Department of Financial Services (DFS) to help promote entrepreneurship among the Scheduled Castes (SC) and Scheduled Tribes (ST) women. It provides loans ranging from ₹10 lakh to ₹1 crore to these under-privileged women entrepreneurs who hope to start businesses in the manufacturing, services, or trading sectors. However, the government here expects the borrower to contribute at least 10% as their own investment. The repayment period may extend up to 7 years with a moratorium of 18 months. This helps in giving these new entrepreneurs enough time to achieve stability (Piramal Finance, 2025).

The Udyogini Scheme is another landmark achievement in fostering entrepreneurship among women. Run by the Women Development Corporation (WDC), the scheme focuses on the economically weaker sections of women and offers them subsidized loans of up to 3 lakh rupees without interest. The key area of this scheme's emphasis is on women belonging to rural and semi-urban areas usually engaged in agriculture or micro enterprises. The Scheme's USP is that it also provides training programs which help raise awareness and works as an effective tool to generate awareness and motivate women entrepreneurs simultaneously (Piramal Finance, 2025).

Yet another scheme introduced by the SBI, *Annapurna* scheme focuses specifically on women entrepreneurs in the FnB industry. It sanctions loans of up to ₹50,000 to help women set up small food businesses in the likes of catering services, tiffin centers and food processing units. Like many schemes discussed above, *Annapurna* too is collateral free but requires a guarantor. The repayment period is flexible and can extend up to 36 months. This allows women to manage their finances optimally while their businesses are still growing (Piramal Finance, 2025).

Finally, the Women Entrepreneurship Platform (WEP) launched by NITI Aayog in 2018 is a planned and structured comprehensive digital mechanism designed especially to support women entrepreneurs. Unlike many other schemes that focus majorly on financial assistance, WEP offers a wide range of tools for women entrepreneurs including mentorship programs, networking opportunities and access to interested investors. The platform also conducts training sessions and workshops to help women enhance their business management skills. It can be called a one-stop solution for women entrepreneurs (Piramal Finance, 2025)

Few other significant steps that have improved the scenario of female entrepreneurship in India can be the 2017 amendment to the Maternity Benefit Act which necessitates every workplace that has at least 50 employees to provide a crèche for women staff. This initiative is designed to make childcare accessible and helps mothers continue their professional careers while caring for their young children or the *Yashasvini* initiative which lays its focus mainly on women entrepreneurs of tier 2 and 3 cities (Arora, 2025). By offering financial support, technical know-how and industry awareness, these schemes play a crucial role in increasing women's participation in entrepreneurship and enhancing job creation.

A Development by the Telangana State Government for the cause of Women

Entrepreneurs in the State

The state of Telangana was formed on 2nd June, 2014 (Narayanpet, 2025). Carved out of Andhra Pradesh, the state had to trace its own path of growth and took a multitude of steps such as State Innovation Cell, T-Hub, T-Works for growth and development. During its growth, it did not take the government a significant amount of time to realize that the underutilized potential of the women in the state can be used to propel it to heights of prosperity.

In 2017, Hyderabad, the capital city of Telangana, hosted the prestigious Global Entrepreneurship Summit (GES). During this summit, the theme adopted was “Women first, prosperity for all”. It primarily concentrated on the agenda to foster entrepreneurship among the women of Telangana by creating a happening environment that inculcates motivation and entrepreneurial skills in aspiring women entrepreneurs – hence, WE Hub was initiated. This was an attempt on part of the government to create a start-up incubator ecosystem where the integral entrepreneurial needs, from the basics to high value concepts of entrepreneurship, would be provided exclusively to women. The end goal of this initiative was to ameliorate the issues of technical, financial and social barriers that had handicapped the women of the region for years. Inconspicuous to the creation of WE Hub was the creation of a self-reliant, high functioning and supportive community of women entrepreneurs who will not just compete with men but may overtake the market in future and contribute in high figures to the growth of women of the state of Telangana and there on, the entire country. Examples of the directly mentioned benefits of WE Hub are easy access to capital, mentors, infrastructure, support services and venture capital pitch events. The platform would also provide new entrepreneurs with guidance on business branding, partnerships, and marketing alongside legal support, peer to peer and founder’s

connections and strategic consulting. Even during its launch in 2017, WE Hub was in touch with 135 incubators and was looking for more to make a pool (Yadadri Bhuvanagiri, 2017).

With WE Hub, the government of Telangana has presented a remarkable example of what can be done for the upliftment of the downtrodden if the authorities actually show concern. The entire nation should take inspiration from it and collectively work together for more such initiatives.

Lapse in the System: Barriers to Being a Woman Entrepreneur in India

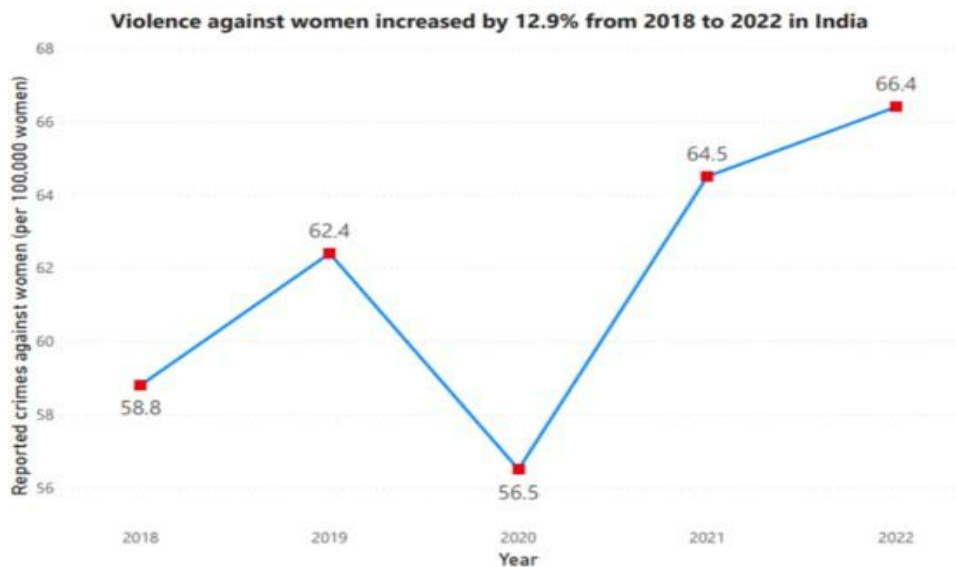
Being an independent and financially autonomous woman in India has always proved to be a challenge. The socio-cultural set up of this country is deeply rooted in a patriarchal structure and it has always pushed its women behind closed doors. Although the situation has improved over the years, the lack of women in entrepreneurial positions can be understood better when observed through the poignantly visible signs of oppression in everyday lives of women and their intersection with entrepreneurship. Women who have achieved financial autonomy in India, whether it is through high ranked job positions or the foundation of a startup, have to face various barriers of gender inequality imposed by society. Below are some of many statistics that portray how difficult it is for a woman to sustain herself, leave aside being an entrepreneur in India.

Crimes Against Women as Barriers to Entrepreneurship in Women

A primary barrier that women in India have to overcome in order to become entrepreneurs or financially independent is the difficulty in staying alive and well. Heinous crimes such as dowry killings, rape and honour killings against women are unfortunately ubiquitous and are at an all-time high across the country. According to a 2022 report by the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB), 4,45,256 crimes were registered against women in

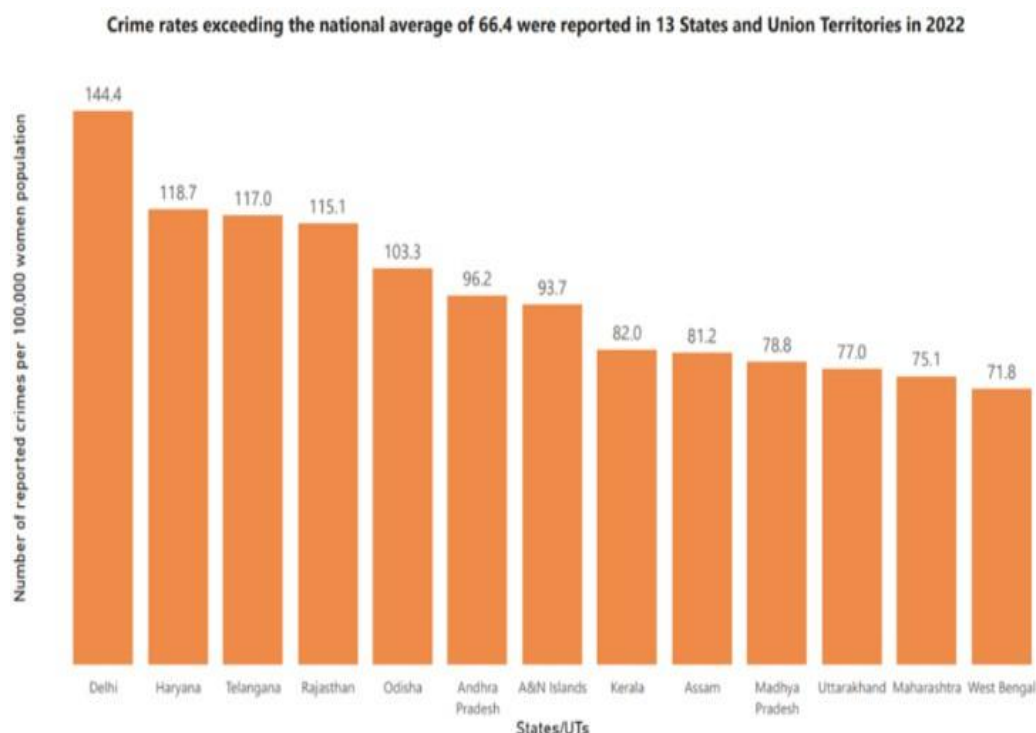
India, roughly translating to 51 FIRs per hour. This was a staggering increase from 4,28,278 cases reported in 2021 and 3,71,503 in 2020 (Verma, 2024). It is important to note that many of these crimes stay unreported due to societal shame, fear of further violence and futility of the action as ascertained by the victim and at times, even when reported, they account for nothing if the perpetrators have political connections. All of these factors enable a terrifying environment where a woman's primary concern shifts from growth and progress to staying alive. An unsafe environment is, in likelihood, the most significant secondary reason why there are so few women entrepreneurs in India.

According to the Women Peace and Security Index (2023) released by the Georgetown Institute for Women, Peace and Security, India ranked 127th out of 177 countries in terms of inclusion, security and justice for women and the situation is aggravating day by day. The National Crime Records Bureau NCRB calculated and revealed that crimes against women increased by 12.9% from 2018 to 2022, increasing to 66.4 per 100,000 women experiencing crimes in 2022 from 58.8 In 2018 (Ansari and Rajaram, 2024). Given below is a visual representation of the same.



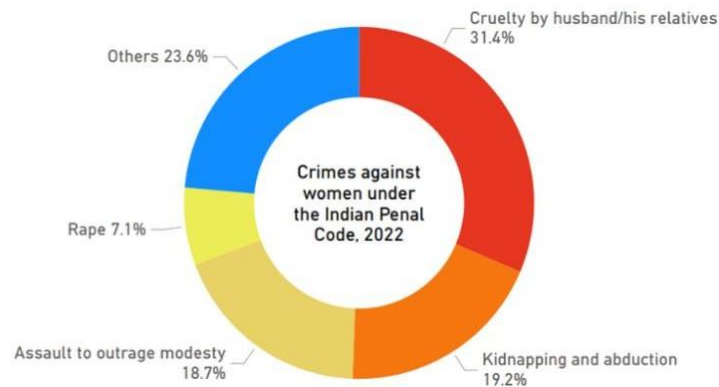
(Ansari and Rajaram, 2024)

The bureau also released a state wise list and to a grave degree, in many highly populated regions of the country, the rate of crime against women exceeded the national average. The bar graph given below illustrates this.



(Ansari and Rajarzm, 2024)

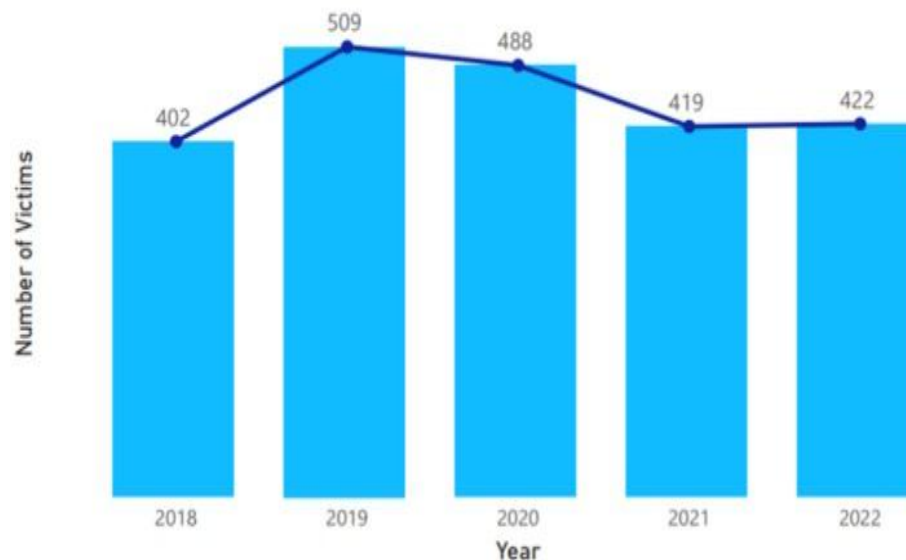
The reports have also revealed the categorization of the type of crimes against women. The majority of crimes committed against women were perpetrated by husband and relatives (31.4%), followed by abduction and kidnapping (19.2%), assault for „immodesty“(18.7%), and rape (7.1%) (Ansari and Rajaram, 2024). Even VAWG (violence against women and girls) is a pervasive issue, and as per WHO, 1 in every 3 women face sexual violence atleast once in their lives and atleast 1 out of 10 girls have been subject to rape. This classification and these statistics related to heinous crimes have revealed even more harrowing details and raise the question: when a large percentage of women find it difficult to even stay alive with dignity, how easy can it be for a woman to start a business in practical life? The pie chart below displays the same.



(Ansari and Rajaram, 202)

Lastly, a major crime which can be linked to restrictive growth of women's entrepreneurship is sexual harassment on workplace. Despite the existence POSH (Prevention of Sexual Harassment) to prevent harassment of women in workplaces being in action since 2013, crimes against women in the workplace have increased from 402 per 100,000 women in 2018 to 422 per 100,000 in 2022 (Anasari and Rajaram, 2024).

Tracking victim count: Trends in workplace sexual harassment against women from 2018 to 2022



(Ansari and Rajaram, 2024)

Notwithstanding, a regrettable and bitter truth is that although a clear link has time and again been established between high literacy and low crime rates (Singh, 2018), women are sometimes not even spared in some of the most progressive and literate societies. A prime example of this can be seen in Kerala where, despite the sex ratio being 1084 females per 1000 men and female literacy reaching a remarkable 92.07% as of 2025 (population Census, 2025), an alarmingly high rate of crimes against women can be observed (Ministry of Home Affairs, 2024). In conclusion, increase in literacy, better healthcare and very few barriers to girl child education have, ostensibly, not been sufficient to keep the women of Kerala safe or enhance their life possibilities (Devika, 2006). It would not be wrong to conclude here, consequently, that the worst barrier of all is the inherently misogynistic and patriarchal mentality of the masses in India. It is also integral to remember that all of these barriers are inter-connected. For example, a low rate of literacy may give rise to a high crime rate, which in turn could give rise to more women being unsafe and less women being able to encash the opportunities and so on. The next paragraph will discuss some news reports which help in indicating the direct relationship between crime and a hostile environment for entrepreneurship in women.

In a distressing event from 2020, Coimbatore (Tamil Nadu), Sangeetha, a transgender social activist and entrepreneur/founder of „Trans Kitchen“ in RS Puram, Coimbatore which was run by all-trans workers, was found brutally murdered in her residence. Sangeetha had previously mentioned how she was not welcome by society and found it to be an arduous task to even find a place to rent. Nevertheless, Sangeetha found ways to enhance the situation of both the trans and women community, and still, in all of her efforts, was brutally murdered. Sangeetha's story is a bold reminder about how patriarchal and homophobic society is and how burdensome it is for women to dream outside their „allowed freedom“ (Thirumurthy, 2020). In 2022, Rincy Nazar, an entrepreneur from Kerala was cut to death by her former employee who later fled the scene. Rincy ran a textile firm on her own (Oommen, 2022). These are just 2 out of

a sea of such terrible headlines that depict how urgent it is to work on reducing crime if the governments are substantive about women entrepreneurs' upliftment. Hence, if governments are truly substantive towards the upliftment of women entrepreneurs, they must work towards lessening crime rates against women to first create an environment in which women entrepreneurs can thrive.

Financial, Infrastructural and Educational Restraints

A basic, primary need to become an entrepreneur is to start up a profitable business; no business can be launched without capital. Financial barriers affect rural and under privileged women more than women belonging to urban set ups due to limited sources of income and dependence on their male counterparts and so, the lack of financing options can be one of the major demotivators for aspiring women entrepreneurs hailing from socio-economically subjugated backgrounds.

According to a study conducted on 60 women entrepreneurs in Telangana, it was found that over 75% of the women earned between 5000-10,000 rupees monthly, giving them barely enough means to survive, let alone starting a venture. Only 2 out of these 60 women earned more than 25,000 in a month (Gayatri, 2021, p.509), depicting the despicable state of affairs. It is hence logical that 1/5th of these women felt very strongly about finance being a major issue in operating a business and some felt that the various taxes imposed are the worst hurdles they face (p.508). Another major financial issue usually faced by budding female entrepreneurs in India is financial exclusion which, in simple terms, is the bank's unwillingness to provide loans to women because of no collateral support, because women in India have long been kept out of bank accounts, digital access and property dealing, owning and lending market for centuries (Kumar, 2023). This lack of credit is a demotivating force for a woman entrepreneur as it is

highly unlikely to raise funds to start a business without some external help. Another major issue is related to venture capital. Venture capital is the sum of money provided to an entrepreneur to launch the business. It is generally provided by investors, investment banks and other financial institutions (Hayes, 2024b). Women all over the world suffer bias compared to their male counterparts when it comes to venture capital as they are judged inferior, seen as lacking the decision making skill and unworthy of investing on. Studies show that women receive 14% less funding compared to their male start up founders and this could possibly be an additional 8% less if the investor has experienced a failure by another woman-led startup in the past (Beyer, 2024). In India, it was found that among 20 most active venture capital investors, many of them like Z47, Stellaris Venture Partners, and Nexus Venture Partners had no women on-board in their investments“ team (The Economic Times, 2025). Solving these problems related to finance can greatly benefit the cause of rural aspiring women entrepreneur in Telagana.

Infrastructural barriers, in addition, have long been a source of complications within the country. Whether it is healthcare, accident fatalities, prices of goods and commodities or entrepreneurship, lack of infrastructure reduces possibilities and opportunities. Fixing infrastructure does not invariably insist on making more buildings, offices and roads. Without doubt, they are also integral in making the country better for women entrepreneurs and they provide easy mobility and storage of the goods and services women entrepreneurs may produce, but in relation to this subject, there is more to infrastructure. In the digital age, every step of the entrepreneurial process involves technical know-how and even the government continues to stress on a digital India so that the beneficiaries (in this case, rural women entrepreneurs) can access help, finance, clients, transactions and essentially all factors which are involved in the

process of running a business: big or small. Infrastructural barriers here would be the digital divide between old and new generation, between poor and rich and between rural and urban women of Telangana. Indeed, this is emphasized by a study which claims that states lag behind in providing efficient online access to schemes. Even schemes that are accessible online do not involve an end to end online process. For example some schemes allow beneficiaries to register online but processes such as the submission of supporting documents is done in the offline mode – this causes confusion and inconvenience amongst potential beneficiaries, and may even cause them to be reluctant towards applying for the scheme. In fact, in the case of state schemes, the study finds that only 27% of schemes offer an online application while the remaining 73% are only available online. Concomitantly, it is clear that numerous government schemes suffer from issues regarding awareness, lack of information regarding the eligibility and language. In the online more, there are many issues regarding non-functional web pages and scheme information only being available in Hindi or English – or only Hindi in some states. Moreover, the study notes that many schemes are channeled through banks – meaning that the beneficiary needs to approach the banks to submit applications, further complicating the process. It should be the primary agenda of the government to not just roll out different digitalized platforms and schemes but to also make sure that they reach the right beneficiaries too. With time, even the people in rural India have slowly caught up on the technical advancements and the goal should be now to reach each and every rural and lower class/caste woman with, at minimum, a smartphone and a stable internet connection to stay up-to-date with the market. Another part of infrastructural barriers for rural women, ST/SC women or women in general is the lack of balance in personal and professional life. It should be a responsibility of the government to provide all rural women with access to sanitized washroom spaces, maternity leaves and workplaces with creches. This

can help women entrepreneurs focus more on their jobs without being at crossroads with their personal lives and hence, be successful entrepreneurs.

When it comes to education, as discussed in sections above, a successful professional career is directly related to education. It is only through education that rural, ST/SC and poor women can first, come at par with their urban counterparts and then to men. Oftentimes, many girl children who go to school drop out immediately after getting basic education. Girls in rural schools should be motivated to pursue higher education and subjects out of their comfort zones such as science and business. Another educational barrier includes linguistic problems. A lot of women, old and young, find themselves more comfortable in regional languages. Although there should be a stress on English language teaching, all information and guidance should also be provided in Telugu and other regional languages. Education also includes awareness and business training and many times, only a few women know about beneficial government policies, interest free loans, no collateral credit system etc. It should hence be a primary agenda, not just of the Telangana government but every other state government too to achieve 100% female literacy and GER and conduct sessions to plan how to disseminate useful entrepreneurial information to under impoverished sections like lower caste and poor women.

Psychological and Socio-cultural Restraints

Psychological barriers in relation to this subject matter refers to the intrinsic and inherent mental hurdles that grip the minds of young women, causing them to limit their aspirations, keeping them in the structure desired by the patriarchy. An example of a psychological barrier in a young girl about becoming a woman entrepreneur could be that when she was growing up, she was either given restricted or no access to dream; to think out of her boundaries and realize that the world outside is full of opportunities was not provided as an option. Perhaps the ideas she

brought up were laughed at or ignored by people of her family and school and now, she thinks that she is only destined to become a wife and raise children. Although there is nothing wrong in that, it becomes problematic when it is not a choice but the only option because the other options such as becoming financially independent, getting a PhD or starting a new business are perceived to be out of reach. The case of psychological barriers in betterment of women's entrepreneurship scenario is a complicated discourse. This complication arises not from the discourse itself being intricate and sensitive to explain but because statistics related to it are generally difficult to acquire. They generally arise from little exposure, low esteem, fear of failure and high end inclination towards comfortable-to-achieve targets. However, when one realizes the importance of government schemes in educating, they may motivate and assist other women in their pursuit in becoming entrepreneurs.

Similarly, socio-cultural norms act as barriers to the generative environment for women in entrepreneurship. As discussed above, socio-cultural barriers include restrictive gender norms which expect women to stay indoors and work around the house, not granting them financial freedom and hence, keeping them dependent on their male counterparts. Another set of these barriers come in the form of family opposition, often leading to crimes of violence against them. For example, if a woman is born or gets married to a traditional and patriarchal family, her chances of going out and exploring the opportunities decrease to almost negligible levels. There is nearly a certain chance of being denied if she ever tries to approach her family elders and seeks funds or freedom to work and establish herself in the open market. Suppose she is somehow able to cross the barrier of family and does step in the market, there is a very high chance that she may not be taken seriously by business clients or investors because of the inherent patriarchal mentality that assumes women to be inferior to men. Consequently, her chances of becoming an

entrepreneur are reduced. It can be said that ultimately, all the schemes for women's welfare are directed towards achieving gender equality.

Policy and Institutional Failures

The final set of barriers are policy and institutional barriers. Frequently, even a well thought out policy fails to register its impact due to this barrier. It includes highly complicated hierarchies and formalities in government offices, burdensome paperwork, less or no official assistance in applying for licence and other documents and so on. These issues lead to the under-utilization of government funds and infrastructure and prevent beneficial schemes from reaching the targeted customer base of rural and underprivileged women entrepreneurs. To give an example, suppose an old lady of lower caste from rural Telangana wishes to start a business of her own. Even after gathering all the required documents and ideas, if she somehow gets trapped in red-tapism and bureaucracy of corrupt officers, she might get demotivated and lose the motivation to continue. It begins a chain of disappointments, withering off trust on government and ultimately, wastage of all the funds allocated for the same. The government should establish digital and physical help centers, advertise them, do door to door campaigning to teach them about entrepreneurship and assign monetary benefits to encourage women in these regions to step out of their houses and dream in the world full of opportunities and government assistance to make an honest, inspiring and fulfilling living. Moreover, even good resulting government policies should be reviewed and re-implemented time and again to match the current needs of the target population.

These barriers appear to be indomitable. However, they can be resolved through planning and optimal usage of resources. The next chapter will deal with the differences among these

barriers themselves, elaborating on how these affect women belonging to different set ups and societal classes

Variance in the barrier's impact: The Question of Literacy, Employment and Social Categorization

After discussing the hurdles in achieving a better environment for women entrepreneurs in the country, it is also important to note that none of these barriers impact all women uniformly. In other words, there is a certain level of privilege that comes into picture. This indicates that uneducated, rural, lower caste, poor and other categories of under privileged women are generally more probable targets of these hurdles and restrictions and, hence, find fewer chances to thrive and succeed in life, and ultimately as women entrepreneurs. Likewise, women with educated backgrounds, belonging to urban regions or hailing from privileged castes have a marginally better chance at becoming financially independent.

For instance, it has been established that in India, the states with high female literacy have recorded the least amount of violence and assault cases against women (Singh, 2018). This directly indicates that by undertaking initiatives such as „*Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao*’, a campaign launched in 2015 that champions young girls’ right to education; *Sukanya Samriddhi Yojana* which encourages parents of girl children to invest a particular sum on which they get a high interest rate of 7.6% pa which matures when their daughters turn 18; *Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalyaya Scheme* (2004) for developing residential infrastructure to female students predominantly belonging to underprivileged castes and below poverty line and various other schemes for girl child education (India Today, 2024), the government understands the impact of education on women, their growth, development and future opportunities they may encounter.

Another example can be of women who reside in rural areas of more patriarchal and traditional states of the country such as Rajasthan, Punjab, Haryana, Delhi and many other regions of Northern India having considerably less opportunities to acquire a profession like entrepreneurship compared to women who live in tier 1 cities like Bengaluru, Mumbai, Pune etc. Some of the states in this part of the country have terrible sex ratios, child sex ratios and highest rates of unemployment and female foeticide in the country (Parihar et. al, 2015, pp.16-24) (Ministry of Labour and Unemployment, 2023, p. Annexure 1). This insinuates that, not only are they at crosspoints with the birth of women, they also have a high number of men unemployed, giving rise to societal evils like crime and drugs, counter productive and even fatal to the growth of women entrepreneurs. Moreover, local judiciaries like village *Khap Panchayats* in many districts of Haryana and Rajasthan are patriarchal in structure and design and for years, have been counter engaging to women achieving financial freedom and liberty through professions like entrepreneurship (Parihar et. al, 2015, pp.16-24).

What ultimately can be said in regard to this is that even though there are multi-faceted challenges in the way of women achieving financial authority through entrepreneurship, these challenges are not unsurpassable and through countless schemes and policies as discussed in chapters above, they can definitely be countered. Although this research paper has been disseminating suggestions throughout its course, the next chapter will elucidate upon some of the suggestions that can help improve the current scenario and then conclude the subject matter.

Suggestions and Conclusions

It can be concluded that the primary restraints which hold women entrepreneurs back from growth are the lack of safety as well as the deeply rooted societal expectations held against women. Indeed, as discussed in above, women in rural or backward areas are especially prone to

these issues, causing them to be exposed to far fewer opportunities than women in urban areas. Presently, the issue with government led policies and laws that aim to protect women are poor in implementation and action, and this needs to be ameliorated. The primary target of the government, apart from implementing new policies, is to resolve the problems with the current ones. Hence, it can be deduced that, if the government is aiming to benefit women entrepreneurs, they must first make adjustments to the existing framework of policies on the protection of women and ensure that they are thoroughly implemented in order to create a stable foundation for these women in the first place.

Nevertheless, it is clear that poor, disadvantaged and rural women require protection from the government as well as overall acceptance from society. The government must restructure and implement laws to help these women flourish as entrepreneurs – this entrepreneurial growth is reliant on a foundation of acceptance, however. Hence, it is also up to society to provide these women with an environment of acceptance.

As mentioned previously, in a study, 60 women entrepreneurs in Telangana were studied and it was found that nearly 87% said that public policies for improving business operating challenges for women entrepreneurs were ineffective (Gayatri, 2021, p.511). It is apparent that the government must secondly ensure that the schemes that are in place must be effective. As previously identified, there are numerous issues regarding the dissemination of knowledge on schemes, language barriers, technological issues, and more with regards to these schemes. Accordingly, the government must ensure that schemes being implemented effectively meet the needs of women entrepreneurs, and that these schemes as well as the existing schemes must lack any faults – this will ensure that women are able to access them. Ela Bhatt, for example, founded „Self-employed women’s association“ (SEWA), a trade union of self employed women textile

workers, and Shaikh Razia, a Chhattisgarh based microbiologist worked on and brought to the front, the nutritional values of *Mahua*, a plant previously only famous for its alcoholic uses among tribes. Razia employed local tribal women and made *Laddoo* and other healthy snacks from it (Sharma, 2023). These examples demonstrate how change can be made in favour of women and rural populations from the grassroots level. It further emphasizes the sheer impact that the government could have if they were to implement the right policies.

It can be concluded that despite the ultimate accountability for the schemes reaching beneficiaries resides with the government, it is the job of every single citizen in the country to respect the women's right to financial security and general safety and assist the government efforts to bring women entrepreneurs equal to their male counterparts, socially, mentally and financially. The primary foundation which must be laid out to create an environment in which women entrepreneurs can flourish is a society in which women feel safe and accepted – it is up to the government as well as society to make this a reality.

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